

Weekly Theta Shortlist — 2026-08-24

Window: Run date 2026-08-24 (Mon). 50-day earnings-free window closes 2026-10-13. Names reporting on or before 2026-10-13 are excluded.

Regime this week: VIX printed a 2026 low near 14.2 intraday on 8/17 and sits ~15.9 — index vol is compressed but single-stock dispersion remains historically wide (VIX/VIXEQ spread ~22 pts). Fed held in July on a divided 9-3 vote; fed-funds futures now price ~65% odds of a +25bp hike at the 9/17 FOMC on stalled Iran talks and a Hormuz-related energy tape. WTI ~\$83, Brent ~\$89, but IEA/OPEC cut 2026 demand and U.S. crude built 17.4mmbbl into 8/7 — two-sided energy vol. No large-cap idiosyncratic blow-ups this week; WMT's -9.2% post-print on 8/21 is the main single-stock scar. FOMC (9/17) sits inside the 45-DTE window opened today — event risk embedded in every trade.

Tier A — November reporters (cleanest window)

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	DTE-earn	Justification (Verify at IBKR)
1	WMT	Consumer Staples	~\$770B	22-30%	20-28%	Yes	2026-11-19 (confirmed)	87	Broad institutional base, penny strikes, weeklies deep. IV likely still elevated from 8/21 -9.2% post-print — wait 2-3 sessions or trade further OTM. Verify at IBKR.
2	HD	Consumer Discretionary	~\$400B	22-28%	20-26%	Yes	2026-11-17 (confirmed)	85	Rate-sensitive housing proxy adds FOMC-day sensitivity. Deep options book, penny-wide. Verify at IBKR.
3	LOW	Consumer Discretionary	~\$140B	24-30%	22-28%	Yes	2026-11-18 (est, date unconfirmed)	~86	Last print 8/19 — realized will drift back to trend. Same rate/housing story as HD. Verify at IBKR.
4	TGT	Consumer Discretionary	~\$60B	28-38%	26-34%	Yes	2026-11-18 to 11-23 (est, date unconfirmed)	~87-91	Higher-beta retailer — better premium than WMT/HD. Watch for single-stock gap risk on holiday guide leak. Verify at IBKR.
5	TJX	Consumer Discretionary	~\$120B	22-28%	20-25%	Yes	2026-11-18 to 11-19 (est, date unconfirmed)	~86-87	Off-price retailer, low realized. IV band may sit near 20% floor. Verify at IBKR.
6	CSCO	Info Tech	~\$285B	22-28%	20-25%	Yes	2026-11-12 (confirmed)	80	Networking, not semi. Well-behaved IV term structure. Verify at IBKR.
7	DIS	Communication Services	~\$210B	26-34%	24-30%	Yes	2026-11-12 to 11-13 (est, date unconfirmed)	~80-81	Higher premium than staples set; parks/streaming beta. Verify at IBKR.
8	DE	Industrials	~\$130B	26-34%	24-30%	Yes	2026-11-19 to 11-25 (est, fiscal Q4, date unconfirmed)	~87-93	Ag-cycle beta — IV typically middle of band. Verify at IBKR.

Tier B — Late October reporters (verify against that window)

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	DTE-earn	Justification (Verify at IBKR)
1	V	Financials	~\$550B	20-26%	18-24%	Yes	2026-10-27 to 10-29 (est, date unconfirmed)	~64-66	Fiscal Q4 (FY ends Sept). Reported FQ3 on 7/28. Steady payments comp — IV often at 20% floor. Verify at IBKR.
2	MA	Financials	~\$470B	20-26%	18-24%	Yes	2026-10-29 to 10-30 (est, date unconfirmed)	~66-67	Same payments read as V. Slightly higher realized. Verify at IBKR.
3	MRK	Healthcare	~\$210B	22-28%	20-26%	Yes	2026-10-22 to 10-29 (est, date unconfirmed)	~59-66	Keytruda cliff overhang keeps premium a touch above pharma comp. Verify at IBKR.
4	PFE	Healthcare	~\$150B	22-30%	20-28%	Yes	2026-10-29 to 11-05 (est, date unconfirmed)	~66-73	Restructuring narrative sustains IV. Watch for pipeline headlines. Verify at IBKR.
5	ABBV	Healthcare	~\$330B	20-26%	18-24%	Yes	2026-10-29 to 11-02 (est, date unconfirmed)	~66-70	Humira erosion mostly priced — IV compressed. Watch for 20% floor breach. Verify at IBKR.
6	LLY	Healthcare	~\$700B	28-38%	26-36%	Yes	2026-10-29 to 11-05 (est, date unconfirmed)	~66-73	GLP-1 headline risk — upper end of band. Reach-for-yield only, tight strangles. Verify at IBKR.

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earnings	DTE-earn	Justification (Verify at IBKR)
7	XOM	Energy	~\$500B	24-34%	22-32%	Yes	2026-10-30 to 11-02 (est, date unconfirmed)	~67-70	Hormuz/Iran tail keeps IV sticky. Vol-spike vega risk on shipping incident. Verify at IBKR.
8	CVX	Energy	~\$285B	26-34%	24-32%	Yes	2026-10-30 to 11-02 (est, date unconfirmed)	~67-70	Same Hormuz story, slightly higher realized than XOM historically. Verify at IBKR.
9	CAT	Industrials	~\$180B	26-34%	24-32%	Yes	2026-10-28 to 10-30 (est, date unconfirmed)	~65-67	Global-cycle beta; captures tariff/rate rhetoric. Verify at IBKR.
10	HON	Industrials	~\$140B	22-28%	20-26%	Yes	2026-10-22 to 10-27 (est, date unconfirmed)	~59-64	Diversified industrial — middle of band. Verify at IBKR.
11	LMT	Industrials	~\$110B	20-26%	18-24%	Yes	2026-10-20 to 10-22 (est, date unconfirmed)	~57-59	Defense — low realized. IV may sit at 20% floor. Verify at IBKR.
12	RTX	Industrials	~\$180B	22-28%	20-26%	Yes	2026-10-27 to 10-29 (est, date unconfirmed)	~64-66	Defense/aero. Similar profile to LMT. Verify at IBKR.

Changes vs last week

First run — no comparison.

Excluded this week (with reason)

- **JPM** — Q3 confirmed 2026-10-13, ON the window boundary.
- **BAC, C, WFC, GS, MS** — bank complex reports 10/14-10/16, too tight to the boundary; skip until Nov.
- **JNJ, UNH** — historically report 10/14-10/15, inside/adjacent to window.
- **KO** (est ~10/21), **PEP** (est ~10/07), **PG** (est ~10/17) — all inside/adjacent to window.
- **COST** (fiscal Q4 late Sept), **NKE** (fiscal Q1 late Sept), **ORCL** (fiscal Q1 mid-Sept), **CRM** (fiscal Q2 late Aug) — earnings inside window.
- **AAPL, MSFT, GOOGL, META, AMZN, NFLX, TSLA** — user rule excludes semis/high-beta tech/meme; also most report late Oct.
- **NVDA, AMD, AVGO, MU, ASML, QCOM, TXN** — semi exclusion.
- **BRK.B** — earnings ~11/01 clean, but IV typically prints below 20% floor.
- **MDLZ, CL, KMB, PG** — staples IV normally at/below 20% floor; skipped even where earnings clean.
- **Regional/energy midcaps (\$10-20B)** — not screened this run; add if user wants more names.

Sizing note for this week

VIX at ~15.9 with the FOMC on 9/17 sitting INSIDE the 45-DTE window is the defining fact: absolute premium is compressed and every position opened today wears Fed event risk. Bias structures to **defined-risk 10-15/6-9 delta credit spreads** over naked strangles this week — the undefined tail isn't paying. Overweight **Tier A** (Nov reporters) where you can hold through the 9/17 Fed vol pop without the earnings overlap; underweight **energy (XOM/CVX)** to a reach-for-yield sleeve only given Hormuz gap risk. **Cap financials (VMA)** at small size — IV likely stays at the 20% floor and offers minimal cushion. Consider deferring new naked strangles until after 9/17 or scale entries in tranches.

Verify at IBKR before trading

Every row above needs live confirmation of: 13w and 26w IV percentile > 50, IV in 20-40% band, HV in 20-40% band, IV/HV between 100% and 150%, and no unreported earnings amendment. This list is a filtered starting universe, not a completed screen.

Sources

- [Chase Insights](#) — Sept 2026 FOMC expectations, energy shock backdrop.
- [OilPrice.com](#) — Brent/WTI levels 8/13, IEA/OPEC demand cuts, Hormuz stalemate.
- [TradingKey](#) — VIX 14.18 intraday low 8/17, ~15.85 on 8/19.
- [Penn Mutual Asset Mgmt](#) — VIX/VIXEQ dispersion ~22 pts, semi vol collapse.
- [MarketChameleon](#) — [WMT](#) — WMT next earnings 11/19/2026 confirmed; last print 8/20 -9.2%.
- [MarketChameleon](#) — [TGT](#) — TGT estimated 11/18-11/23/2026.
- [WallStreetHorizon](#) — [HD](#) — HD next earnings 11/17/2026 confirmed.
- [Investing.com](#) — [LOW](#) — LOW last print 8/19/2026 (Q2); next report is Q3.
- [BusinessWire](#) ([TJX prior](#)) — TJX prior-year Q3 pattern (Nov 19) — used to estimate 2026.
- [MarketChameleon](#) — [CSCO](#) — CSCO next earnings 11/12/2026 confirmed.
- [JPMorgan IR](#) — JPM Q3 2026 confirmed 10/13/2026 — boundary exclusion.
- [MarketChameleon](#) — [PFE](#) — PFE est 10/29-11/05/2026.
- [Visa IR](#) ([prior year](#)) — V FY end Sept; prior-year FQ4 pattern 10/28 — used for est.
- [CNBC](#) ([fetch failed](#)) — 403 — used tradingkey summary instead.